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SOUTH CHICAGO CHAPEL FUNERAL HOME

Records detail decrepit conditions

Investigators find maggots, rat feces and a body in a bathroom

By Olivia Olander,
Talia Soglin,
Madeline Buckley
and Sam Charles
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

On Aug. 3, state investigators inspecting the notorious South Chicago Chapel were confronted with an overwhelming smell and a nightmarish scene.

In a ramshackle building, the temperature in one storage area rose to 88 degrees, as dozens of bodies decomposed, rats scurried around the area, and maggots covered some of the remains.

Public records obtained by the

Tribune, as well as a newly filed city lawsuit, describe how bad conditions had gotten at the South Side funeral home before state and local officials intervened in the wake of the discovery of 56 decomposing bodies at the facility at 2939 E. 95th St. A Tribune investigation earlier this month showed how state agencies missed warning signs, leaving horrified family members to contemplate how their loved ones were treated with such little care.

The owners, Clark and Johanna Morgan, could not be reached for comment.

In a housing complaint filed Friday in Cook County Circuit

Court, the city's Department of Buildings charged a host of code violations against the funeral home, listing five pages of alleged dangerous, hazardous and unsanitary conditions that officials say overran the facility.

The lawsuit — along with a complaint filed by the Illinois Department of Financial and Professional Regulation and an investigation report by the city's Department of Business Affairs and Consumer Protection — offers new details on the decrepit environment at the funeral home, which has led



Workers remove bodies from the South Chicago Chapel funeral home on Aug. 7. **ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

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LEAD EXPOSURE, LOST HISTORY AND A RUNAROUND

How changes to the Wacker House go beyond a preservation fight

By Tess Kenny | CHICAGO TRIBUNE

When Elizabeth and Hunter Case toured what would become their family home in Old Town, life in the house was easy to picture.

They saw the kids they'd planned to have filling the big open space. They saw the Christmas tree they'd place in the front window, the garden they'd cultivate outside.

What they didn't anticipate were the doctor's visits, the calls to police, the lawyers. And the feeling that it all could have been prevented had someone listened and taken a closer look next door.

For years, an Old Town homeowner has been making unlawful alterations to his property — at the expense, neighbors say, of the house's historic roots and their own safety.

Known as the Wacker House, the home has been a hallmark of the city's North Side for more than 150 years, dating back to the Great Chicago Fire. The property has historical protections both locally and nationally, which — on paper — should mean that projects are well-vetted and, if approved, conducted with its longstanding tenure in mind.

Unauthorized work, however, is overrunning the structure, according to neighbors and city records. Since 2023, the contested construction has spurred more than two dozen requests for service to various city departments, three stop work orders and an inspection by federal officials.

For the Cases, who live next door, the changes go beyond

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Above: Elizabeth and Hunter Case stand in their backyard in Old Town as they look at the Wacker House next door on Aug. 21. The owner stripped lead paint from the exterior of the historic home, exposing the Cases' young daughter to the substance.

EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Statement: New system under Trump order flawed

Whistleblower: USPS plan could jeopardize process for mail ballots

By Nicholas Riccardi
ASSOCIATED PRESS

The U.S. Postal Service is poised to launch a hastily built, error-riddled computer system that could jeopardize the process of mail voting relied upon by one-third of all voters, according to a whistleblower statement released Tuesday by Democratic Sen. Richard Blumenthal.

The effort is part of the implementation of President Donald Trump's executive order limiting mail voting and has been temporarily halted by a federal judge. The ruling is being appealed by the administration and the directive may ultimately end up back before the U.S. Supreme Court.

The disclosure from the unidentified whistleblower contends that the Postal Service has been scrambling to try to build a complex system that would normally take a year or more in only three months, sometimes in defiance of the judge's orders halting work. The goal is to have it ready for use in the midterm elections.

The disclosure contends that, due to the new procedures, a single scanning error in a batch of tens of thousands of ballot envelopes could prevent any from reaching voters. It details a system that election officials have already warned could not be implemented before the first mail ballots begin going out Friday in North Carolina.

"The Postal Service has designed a system to disenfranchise millions of Americans," Blumenthal told reporters in advance of releasing the whistleblower information. "This administration seems hell-bent on changing the framework on casting

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INSIDE

US, Iran declare attacks retaliatory

The U.S. military hit targets in Iran on Tuesday, and Tehran fired missiles and drones in response as hostilities flared again in the war between the two countries. **Nation & World, Page B4**

Nostalgic comfort in Logan Square

The Chicago brewery and distillery Maplewood now has a chef who's making nostalgic American comfort food with unexpected Eastern European whimsy. **Food & Health**

'Gargantuan' hailstone breaks state record

The 6.6-inch pellet fell during March storms in Kankakee

By Adriana Pérez
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Think about a large can of soup, being thrown at you 80 miles an hour.

That's about how much the largest hailstone recorded in Illinois weighs, said Ian Giammanco,

lead research meteorologist at the Insurance Institute for Business and Home Safety.

The institute helped weigh and measure the stone after it was found in a Kankakee backyard during severe storms this March. At 6.6 inches, it officially broke the previous, 11-year record, held by a 4.75-inch stone that fell near the village of Minooka, the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration announced Tuesday.

The process to confirm and

verify the record took six months — "as far as science goes, not too bad," said Trent Ford, the Illinois state climatologist, who led the committee that evaluated the findings.

The announcement, Ford said, puts a cap on a year "that has just been nuts" in terms of weather across the state.

Victor Gensini, a meteorologist and professor of atmospheric

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The 6.6-inch hailstone found by the Dorris family in Kankakee on March 10 is scanned at Northern Illinois University in DeKalb on March 17. **TROY STOLT/FOR THE CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

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